Reflection on “As We May Think”

Vannevar Bush wrote this essay in 1945, near the end of World War II, when scientific research and technology were developing very quickly. He wants to use the knowledge that already existed so that people could access, organize and connect them to create more information.

Bush’s idea about the relationship between “thinking man and the sum of our knowledge” is interesting because he recognizes that human memory have limitations but he also sees human as creators and users of knowledge . We can see different technologies developed toady based on his ideas to store the data of different sectors where we can store all the information and can be access whenever we need it.

Bush’s idea about the memex became important because he imagined personal device that could store books, records, communications, notes, photographs and other information . To me , this shows that bush did not imagine technology simple replacing human thinking instead he imagined technology extending human memory and helping make connections.

One of Bush’s speculations was that information technology would be possible to store amount of information and retrieve it through different medium. He was directly involved in scientific research during world war II where he had direct experience with both the power of scientific collaboration and the problem of managing huge amount of research from where he believed scientists should use the new technologies for making human knowledge more accessible.

Based on that one example that relates strongly to bush’s ideas is Google NotebookLM which was released in 2024 which allows users to upload sources such as PDFs, Google docs, slides, websites, youtube videos and audio files and then interact with those sources using AI which can summarize information, answer questions, create study guides, and make connections between different sources. I see a strong connection between NotebookLm and Bush’s Memex where bush imagined a personal information system where a person could keep a large collection of knowledge and move between connected pieces of information where a notebooklm does something similar in a modern way.

My own speculation is that future technology will move even further from simply storing information. For example, the technology allow people to interact with information without physically touching the device. For example, as we discussed in class to about hand free interactions where future AR glasses could use cameras and sensors to track a person’s eyes, hand gestures, and voice which we can use it to track a document , hand gesture to save it and connect it to another document simply by moving their hands. This connects to our class discussion about free hand interaction devices because it shows how technology could move away from keyboards and touchscreens.

In a class discussion different points were raised related to Bush’s idea which I totally agree with because in part of my analysis I also found the same because I can connect class discussion with the concept of NotebookLM and hand free interactions . As we also talk about future concepts of

AI how ai can bring the future concept of accessing the data stroing the information and the movement of hand gestures leading to make an robots which can be programmed as human doing artificial works by on their own.

REFERENCES

Bush, V. (1945). As we may think. *The Atlantic*.

https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/1945/07/as-we-may-think/303881/

I honestly have not use Ai .